Words left Unsaid...

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/59064001.

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General Audiences

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

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F/F, Gen

Fandoms:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018), Original Work

Relationships:
Original Character(s)/Original Character(s), Original Female Character(s)/Original Female Character(s)

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by nimuewrites

Summary

A story of two childhood friends with differing histories meeting through a wall of moss and old cement and the circumstances leading them to a fall out. They are now approaching the end of high school comes, and a choice comes at an afternoon: to mend their bond, or to end it once and for all. Memories come like a wave, as two girls go through life dealing with what life has given to them.

Notes

Hello! :) This story is actually me trying to get back into writing from a slump of almost a decade of not writing. English is not my first language, so bear with me trying to go through grammatical errors and whatnot. With that said, this story is actually inspired from the relationship progression I saw with Catradora from SheRa. I like childhood friends to enemies to strangers to enemies again to friends to lovers so why not make a fanfic that is semi-inspired by them?? If you are reading this, hope you'd enjoy reading this one too.

See the end of the work for more notes

“Cassandra! Come on Cassie, we’re going to be late!”

“Coming!” shouted a young brunette in uniform, clutching her bag hurriedly as she zoomed past the classroom and among the crowded students. Her hair on a ponytail, eyes determined, she scurried to the stairs above, sweat dripping down her cheeks. *Please let me be on time* , she thought. Despite people greeting her as she passed through, she only gave a grim smile as she ran and ran, searching for the familiar sign of the Student Council’s Room. Minutes pass by, her palms gripping on her bag straps now sweaty and lungs heaving, she took a deep breath as she tried to calm herself down in front of the room, eyeing a plastered bond paper and tape saying “Student’s Council”. Taking a deep breath, she entered the room, seemingly unbothered in contrast to her body tired from running, greeting everyone inside in her perfect, seamless toothed smile. The room was appropriately sized for a club room, with four metal desks lined at each side of the room, equidistant with one another. One main desk is placed opposite from the sliding door, with a desk name plate saying “Student Council President” at the corner of the table. At the center of the room lay a metal circular table designated as a meeting table for organizing school activities and events. She pranced through the room, laying her eyes on the members of the organization.

Three students, seated down at a metal circular table, stared at her whilst smiling back. “Hello Pres!” greeted one student named Belle, with auburn curls mirroring her smile; a record book and black stylus pen on the side, probably her Minutes of the Organization, Cassandra thought. “Took you long enough to slowpoke” teased another male student, head supported by both of his hands while smirking playfully. His gem earrings on view, Cassandra huffed “And here you are still breaking the rules Stephen. Tell me, what student in position, handling our school’s finances, would deliberately leave her friend despite promising her

that both of them would go to the Student Council's room for fun, Stephen?". "Ah… you wound me my friend, I thought we were friends. No friends would rat out their friends" Stephen grumbles, head now placed on the cold metallic surface of the table, pouting. Cassandra massages her eyebrow creases, headache starting to form as she settles her messenger type bag on the table. She then took out a blue plastic folder fastened with a yellow fastener and placed it on the table. She passed documents to her members, signing to Belle the start of the planned meeting. The auburn girl prepped her phone, scanning through her phone. Before she could go to the recording app, a slam permeated across the room. Four pairs of eyes scanned the source of the noise, expressions ranging from mildly annoyed to shocked.

A short, ebony haired girl in her teens, hunched over, her right palm gripping the edge of the door, stared at them; mouth open as she tried to catch her breath. She composed herself, dusting off the invisible dust of her knee length skirt and pranced through the room, seating beside Cassandra. Cassandra, staring at her with sarcasm in mind, scoffed at her, with a smirk. "Look who's having her grand entrance" Cassandra bemused. Three students had their eyes on both of them, sensing a tense atmosphere already brewing within the room. Belle, trying to sort out on what to do, makes eye contact with Stephen, now wide eyed and tense whilst staring at Cassandra. "Well, uh, since Vice Pres is now present, maybe we should start the meeting agen-" intervened a now stiff blonde male, gripping the now crumpled document, his blue eyes darting both at the smirking Cassandra and the pissed off member. A bemused voice interrupts him, mirroring Cassandra's amused attitude and tries to deflect. "Still as catty as last time, Cassie?" she singsongs, her head leaning at the side. "And here I thought the ever loving President Cassie would be so professional in her duties. Such a two faced liar, aren't you?" she jeers, crossing her arms with her right leg now on top of the other.

Something silently breaks, the three spectators realized; it was too late when Cassandra stood up, hands on the table now slammed, staring heatedly at the now smirking jeering member, her teeth grating as she tried to retort. Before she could do it however, Stephen swiftly places himself between them, hands open at both of them, with a voice both calm and playful at the same time. “Now, now, we don’t want any more broken furniture at the office, okay? Both of you know how Ms. Ragnivindr gets heated about that, so why don’t we settle down and have this conversation at a later time, okay, Lovebirds?” he beckons at both of them. “We are not lovebirds!” two voices filled with exasperation and vigor denied in unison. He chuckles, eyes filled with mirth staring at both girls whilst saying “All right whatever you say. Also, Sophia, I know you can be a bit of a diva but please no more bickering at Cassie for the rest of the meeting? Our poor cutie Auditor Christian here can’t take the sexual tension here”. He beckons at the now teary eyed blonde. “Right Christian?” he smiles toothed. Christian clears his throat at the comment, trying to not feel bothered and affected by the situation, signing at Belle to just start the meeting already. “I am not a diva, you clown”, Sophia razzes on, “besides, she started it. I am just defending myself, right Catty?”. She rattles on, purposefully avoiding Cassandra’s irritated gaze, eyes boring on Stephen. He shrugs, content, placing his feet at a vacant seat, waiting for the meeting to start. “Shut it, Princess~” Cassandra sings, seemingly happy staring at Sophia’s vexed expression. Before she could retort, Belle cuts through their bickering. “Let’s just start this already. I have a cat to feed” she uttered, her usual calm voice now filled with annoyance.

All of them then scanned through the passed document, with Cassandra’s prior annoyed and playful tone now calming down and serious. “Let’s get to it, shall we?”. All eyes were now on her.

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"That was a disaster huh? Cassie?" Stephen mused, now biting at a ham and cheese sandwich, sneering at the now flushed and annoyed Cassandra. They were now at the academy's cafeteria near the school's garden; hushed whispers surrounding both of their presence.The cafeteria was crowded with students of differing grades; screams filled with orders and chatter gathered, filling the building with the feeling of youth. Numerous students filled the once vacant tables, going through their respective group of friends heedless to the other students in the academy. Each of the students munched through the day along with their food and drinks. Despite that however, they kept an eye on their infamous Academy Student President, watching her like vultures thirsty of gossip as she continued to chomp on her eviscerated chicken salad; the petunia's and yellow roses from the garden smiling at her plight.

"I don't understand what's her problem", she chews, "she keeps on trying to provoke me, vindicating me like I am some sort of evil of her life that she wants to destroy". She stares at her friend, pouting and grumblin, her once perfect ponytail now having baby hairs falling down. Stephen, still chewing his lunch, smiles at her knowingly and speaks. "I don't know about you, but it sounds like both of you still have animosity with one another. Aren't you tired though? This is, like, the 4th year of both of you still arguing like cats and dogs", he rants. "Cassie, I love you and I worry about you, but isn't it time for you to, I don't know, confront her about this? We're now in our fourth year, we're going to graduate and turn into semi-adults next year, as much as I dread to think about it". Cassandra, not buying everything her friend tells her, erupts,

now defensive. “But she doesn’t listen to me! She has hurt me countless times, not even counting that one time that she goaded me into thinking that someone had a crush on me in third year, only to realize that she only did that to play on my weakness. What makes you think I would want to be friends with her?”. She huffed in ire, finishing her chicken salad doing a slam and stab on a piece of chicken.

“He’s right, you know?” a bright and cheery voice interrupts the conversation. Stephen and Cassandra both halted, staring at the owner of the voice, only for them to smile in unison. Cassandra stands up and hugs the culprit, almost lifting her up in glee. Stephen, on the other hand, places his cheek on top of his left hand, staring at the intruder, smiling. “Did art class make your ears bleed Ava?” he teases. Ava, the girl in question, scoffs at Stephen’s remark. He hurriedly moved over to the other side, making way for Ava as she sat, ignoring Stephen’s comment. “Shush now, wonder boy, now tell me what happened this time between Cassie and the diva?” she places her gaze on the annoyed Cassie, whose mood turned sour at the mention of the topic. Stephen and Ava gawk at each other, communicating through their eyes. Closing her eyes and sighing, Ava places her fingers at her temples whilst observing Cassie’s reaction. “Don’t tell me it happened again? Nevermind, don’t answer that. That was rhetorical”. Cassie looks at her friend, guilty and sheepish. She started it though, Cassie thought. It felt like it was Sophia’s motive to ruin her day. She never did talk to her, that much she realized but Sophia never gives her an opportunity to have a one on one conversation. She also doesn’t see the point of them talking, she reasons. She was about to respond when Ava shushed her, her fingers on her lips. She gawks at her friend in defeat as Ava stares at her, hard.

“I thought we already talked about this thing for like, I don’t know, millions of times? I can already feel my hair going gray

everytime you talk and rant about her. We're halfway through our last semester. Isn't it like time for both of you to resolve that rift you had since the first year?" Ava explains, almost like a mother scolding a child. I know, Cassie relents. She knows that this year would be the last time that both of her closest friends can hang out together. She is aware that after graduation, they would go on their separate ways: Ava going on a HumSS strand to a different province on a scholarship and Stephen plowing through ABM strand to succeed his father's business. She tries to escape from it, focusing on the extra curricular activities that she had taken out of impulse since the start of the second year, yet she feels it looming around her, breaking her perfected hyper-independent persona of hers. "Don't you want to have regrets Cass?" Ava asks her, staring at her eyes, searching for something she doesn't recognize. She already has numerous regrets in her life, that she admits. From her trying her best to vie for her parent's attention like the obsessive maniac she admits, to the strained situationship she had with Sophia, who still confuses her at her core. Cassie acknowledges that she herself doesn't know what she wants in the future, and is just prolonging the inevitability of choosing, feeling that the world and the expectations people have on her weighing on her own shoulders.

"I am… trying. In my own way… " she speaks, almost as if she's convincing herself. Lips pursed, eyes watering and confused, she stares at the garden once again; the pink camellias mocking her. Her thoughts pile up, drowning her lungs, as if she is swimming through an ocean of uncertainties. She tires of it, she thought. Moments of when she thought she was ever happy seemed bleak, too unreal, alike of the figments of her imagination, like the imaginary thoughts she had when she was still alone at her home. One thought pierced through her contemplation, a voice that always had brought comfort to her once plagued mind, seeking, but not reaching.

I will always be your friend, Catty.

Stephen and Ava both looked at Cassie worryingly. They didn't want their friend to suffer. Both of them knew she craved affection and relationships, despite her subtly coming off as too independent. In spite of Cassie always complaining about Sophia antagonizing her and their bickering, they both knew it stemmed from their past, which both of them weren't aware of. Cassie had always put walls between them that they can't even penetrate, no matter how hard they try to let them in. Soph seemed to have those walls broken down and thickened, pushing Cassie to think of vulnerability as something she has to eradicate, that she has to avoid. It saddened them greatly, birthing more questions from them as to what even happened that ended them up this way.

Cassie stares at the drooped blue cornflowers at the garden as the skies turn dark.

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Along the crevices of the mossed cement walls around what she deems as a prison, she finds her dreams of seeing what lies beyond there going stronger as she passes through her natal days of her childhood. She caresses her Melody stuff toy, looks for comfort through her black bead eyes as she tries to imagine her voice from the series that she always watches. "It's okay, I'm right here Sophie!" she would probably say. "Come on, let's go and

play" she would probably goad her. It's okay, I have Melody by my side, she bemuses. She won't feel alone. Mama and Papa will take her to her favorite zoo, they promised her, she thought to herself. Satisfied, she went to her usual empty living room, where at the side lies a sliding door opening to the veranda and into their family garden. She tries to be a good girl and not go outside. Her mother promised her if she does that, she'll let her go to her workplace again, this time without disturbing her compared to prior instances.

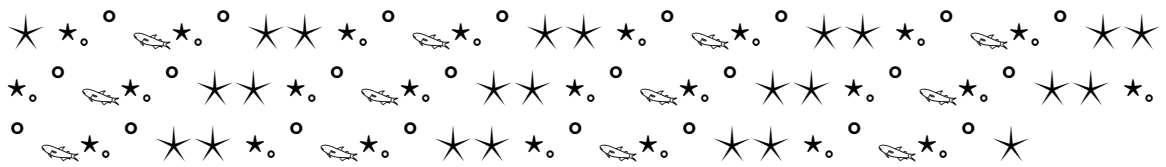
An hour passed, and she found herself bored to death as she kept on rewatching her favorite My Melody series over and over again, having by now memorized it all. Finding a new sort of entertainment, she gaped again at the green, decaying cement walls of their fences, wondering if she could go outside again like Mama and Papa used to. The moss seemed to be calling to her, her curiosity peaked. Mama and Papa wouldn't know, she reasoned. She'll just go to the flower gardens and nothing more. Pleased by her reasoning, she ran through the couch and jumped, landing on the furnished wooden floor with practiced ease. As a precaution, she looks around for any semblance of hidden cameras in the room and finds a sole camera at the plotted plants beside the glass door. She pretends to retreat back into the couch and acts like she would go back into her own room, before getting a towel and tiptoeing behind the potted plant and covering it. Content, she grabs her Melody plush doll and hastily opens the glass door, scramming to get to the garden.

Unbeknownst to her knowledge, a Melody keychain flew through the cracks of the wall, followed by the screams of panic and agitation from the other side of the moss wall. A girl, who looks like a kindergartener, stares at the hole of the huge walls of a mansion where her My Melody keychain passed through. She grumbles in annoyance, cursing and blaming the world for her misfortunes of her hard earned prize. It's unfair, she moans. She

won it fair and square from defeating her close friend in a battle of Roblox. She stomps her grievances out of her and stares at the wall filled moss and vines that took away her prize. "I'll get it if it's the last thing I do" she murmurs, eyes set on a hanging vine on the wall. She places her slippers on her elbows and tugs on the hanging vine, checking if it's enough to hold her weight. It moves and creaks. Pleased with her assessment, she climbs on the wall by pulling her weight on the lone vine, wrapping it around her hips and using it as a rope to climb, similar to what she saw in the movies. It had shockingly worked, until she slipped and screamed involuntarily. She instinctively palms on the wall for support, where she grabs at a decaying block of cement out of luck, saving her from a possible fracture. Feeling her heart colliding at her rib cages, she motioned on, letting her fear of falling not get on her nerves. She then reached to the top of the wall, where she met brown eyes staring at her in shock.

"Umm… who are you?" the girl in question, brunette with tips reaching at her back, asked warily. She looked like she wanted to bolt, the girl thought. She was wearing a pink dress, shoeless on the ground, clutching at a Melody stuff toy like it was her lifeline. A thought came to the girl. She's pretty, she thought. She's pretty, but why are her eyes empty, she reflected. Noticing that she hadn't replied at all, she screamed "Umm… I am Sophie! Uhh… I climbed to find my Melody keychain, it passed through the wall!". The brunette contemplated in understanding, shouted in reply "Oh… well I am Cassandra! I'll help you find it!" with a shy smile. Sophie felt something warm on her chest for the first time. She decided that she wants to befriend her, right then and there.

But first, she needs to find a way to get down.



“You do realize that you have been having this old couple's quarrel for years now, right? Aren't you tired of this Sophie? Are you even listening to me wildcat?” a student rattled beside Sophie, her red twintails now in disarray from trying to lecture her friend and keeping her other friend, now sprawled on school campus ground, in check.

“What is there to realize Alliyah?” Sophie rebuttals, innocently munching as if nothing happened. Alliyah, now in distress, tries to keep her composure as she stares at Sophie like she grew two heads. The atmosphere on the sports field at their academy with the blaring heat is not making her temper cool any better. She takes in a deep breath, squatting at the grass as she squares to look at Sophie eye to eye. Sophie, not affected, just stared at her smiling, chill and unbothered. Their staredown got interrupted however, by a barrage of screaming and howling from their other friend, giggling on the grass with her phone open. Alliyah grumbles in frustration, and turns to her giggling friend. “Do you mind?”. Said friend, now clutching her phone like a lifeline, unamused stares at Alliyah like she had ruined her lunch, at a heated Wednesday noon at all that. She tries to sit down, feet apart from one another, knees touching. The bluenette, now exasperated, stares at Alliyah, arms at her hips and chatters. “I was reading besties to enemies to strangers to friends again to lovers fanfiction and you ruined the moment. What do you want? ”. Alliyah gapes at her unamused and states a matter of factly. “Keep on reading fanfiction and you'll have a life filled only with stories, fantasies and dying alone with eleven cats, Rae”. Rae, looks shocked and attacks as she pushes Alliyah's shoulder, in

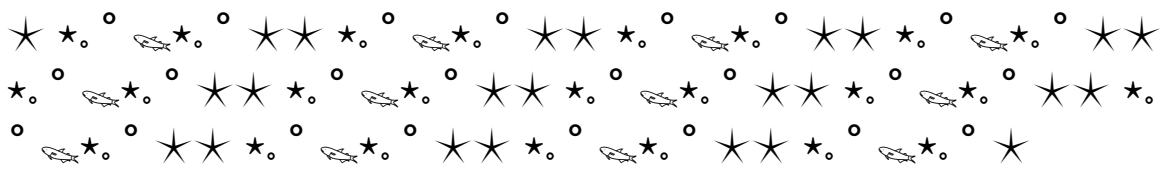
denial. Sophie watches in mirth as she observes both of her friends interacting. She relaxes, moving from a sideway sitting position to clutching both of her knees, bending her back whilst her head on her knees. Alliyah notices, averting her attention back to Sophia. She sits beside her, head on her side and asks, "Is something wrong?". Rae, now sensing her friend's mood, stops reading and places her phone on the grass. She moves in front of Sophia, hands on top of her dorsal feet, waiting for her to speak. Sophia, feels tender as she basks on her friends' open affection but finds it hard to speak up, pain at her throat making it hard to. She takes a deep breath and places her forehead on her knees, voice buckling.

"You say that, but I didn't even know where it all went wrong" Sophia sighs. Both girls look at each other, speaking in some sort of telepathic communication. Both red and blue stare at her back, and motion in hugging her; the red head situated at her back and the blue head in front. They didn't utter a word, it wasn't needed. Both of them knew words don't mean anything to Sophia, actions do. It only hurt her, plagued her mind that she is only privy to and her friends are not aware of. Sophia takes a deep sigh, calming herself down, willing herself to not cry in front of them. This is my problem, she reassures herself. Everything that happened was inevitable. She is bound to be alone. Love is finite, that's what a part of her blood always drilled into her mind. She hated every fiber of their being, but she also admits that a part of her longs for them. The friends she has are the only ones she has and would ever confide in, despite missing another part of her lost from the day she witnessed being thrown away. No, she argues. She shouldn't miss it. She was thrown away, that was a fact. She was only wanted due to convenience, and was tossed away when she wasn't anymore needed.

It was all there what it was, right?

Please, don’t leave me…

She mulls over it again, trying to ignore those words, her voice, her promises. She denies again and again. Build more walls, she shouts in her head. Be more angry, she shouts again. Hate her, cast her aside, leave her be, she commands. But, why is her heart not listening?



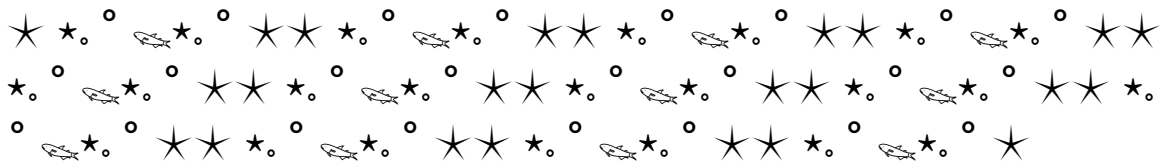
“Catty! Let’s go play in the garden!” Sophie shouts, now ten years old, her curly ebony hair in twintails, grabbing both of Cassie’s hands to the veranda.

She looks at Cassie, her best friend for five years and counting, she adds, her brunette locks on a high ponytail, paired with a blue blouse and shorts. Cassie, shy and worried, shoots her a look of fear, shaking her head. “My parents don't want me to, and I don’t want them to be angry at me again” she explains to Sophia. Sophia, annoyed, places both of her hands on her hips, acts animatedly, and declares “Then I will explain to them, that all children need some sunshine, and have some fun” whilst giggling.

She softly touches Cassie's elbows and looks at her in the eye. "And if they get mad at you, I'll be the one to defend you. I will wipe your tears and play with you". She pauses, poses like a princess from the movie she watched yesterday, her hands now squeezing Cassie's hands and smiling. "I will always be your friend, Catty".

Cassie, feeling happy and reassured, gawks and laughs at her. "You sound like a Disney Princess', she laughs. Sophie pouts at the comment and retorts, "What can I say, maybe I am a Princess, unlike your cat-like mannerisms, Catty". She smirks at her, watching Cassie go from exasperation to a playful attitude. She crosses her arms, huffs haughtily at Sophia. "At least I don't act like I'm a star in a Disney Princess movie, Princess". Laughter ensues as both girls enter the garden in glee. Cassie stares at Sophia in wonder, feeling contented and happy.

Unbeknownst to them, every friendship has its own cracks.



Sophia scrambles to hasten her clean up duties as Alliyah and Rae beckon her to leave homeroom together. She does it swiftly and with practice, setting her mind at ease from a habit that she likes to delve into whenever she feels pensive. Alliyah's words still send

her reeling at the thought of trying to be friends with Cassandra again, but feels trapped as she tries to even fathom that they would have that close friendship again in the future. She was the one who discarded me, she defends in her head. She chose her side, and I chose mine, she adds on. She contemplates going through the clean up duty chores robotically until she was left with throwing the trash at the back of the building. She relents, putting her reflection on hold as she goes outside, going down from a third story building and onto their school garage where the trash bins are. She places the trash and was about to go on her merry way when she hears muffled crying at the back of the garage. Distraught, she convinces herself that no, this is not her problem. The stranger in question was probably having a moment, she muses, and doesn't need a stranger like her to comfort them. She is not a therapist, she adds on. She can't heal people. She is already broken in the first place. She doesn't need another broken person to heal for her to feel self-satisfaction.

She doesn't need to, she convinces herself.

Her feet bring her to the back of the school garage. This is a bad idea, she thought. But her heart tells her otherwise. As she keeps on searching for the source of the cries, her eyes widen as she stares at those empty brown eyes, her brunette ponytail at disarray, knees on chest, forehead tucked in and lungs heaving as she hears her cry. She swallows, her throat dries and tries to move her feet away from her, frozen. She tries to speak but feels her voice taken away and only sputters. The stranger stops her heaving, confused, and lifts her head, only to see the familiar shoulder length raven hair and hazel eyes staring at her in shock.

Cassie stiffens as she sees Sophia, a deer in headlights. She was caught in the act; her breakdowns were personal and private. She

felt her personal space was violated and her composure broke even more. She laughs to herself, laughing at the irony to be caught at a moment of weakness by her past best friend now turned enemies. She waits for the moment to get worse, to burn, to explode. She waited for the seconds to be over, but silence only prevailed. Only the breeze from the schoolyard and their bated breaths were heard, until she heard feet shuffling, approaching her. On alert, she tries to scoot away, but a hand on her shoulder halted her escape. She gawks at her as Sophia, in their three and a half years of passive aggressiveness, gives her a handkerchief. She looks at her face, searching for something that may denote that she is trolling, making a fool out of her. All she saw was sincerity, concern, and… guilt.

"Take it", Sophia whispers, hand shaking. She observes as Cassie looks at her like she grew another head, shock on full display. She sighs deeply, gestures it again, until Cassie takes it in in silence, wiping her tear stricken face. Once Casse took her handkerchief, she silently sat beside her, three inches away from her, hands on the ground. She searches Cassie's face, searching for any indication of her being afraid or scooting away, but she sees none. She averts her sight back at the school fence, the place devoid of any juniors and elementary students. She tries to speak again, this time more soft. "What happened?". Cassie, her shock now gone, instinctively tries to argue with her. She almost lashes out until Ava's words echoes in her mind.

Isn't it like time for both of you to resolve that rift you had since the first year?

"... I couldn't take it" she whispers in reply, breathing while trying to control her emotions. "I broke down" she adds on, her voice full of self depreciation and sarcasm as she tries to laugh it off,

like it was all normal. She stares at the school fences, her gaze glazed over out of self-pity. Sophia looks at Cassie again, this time, concerned and wanting to comfort the broken girl in front of her slowly fizzing out. Her common sense tries to reason her heart. Why does she even bother caring again? Why does she bother letting another person enter the walls she built again? She will come out hurt and bleeding once again. She is already happy isn't she? She has two of her closest friends, who loved her despite her carefree attitude. She reasons again, why does she always yearn for something impossible? Didn't her own blood leave her because of that?

But her friends didn't know her that well, unlike Cassie.

Aren't you tired of this Sophie?

Please don't leave me…

Sophia reaches for Cassie's left hand, not caring for the consequences of her own actions. Consequences be damned, her heart soars. She caresses it, soothing Cassie's thumb as she feels it stiffen, but relaxing within seconds. Cassie, surprised once again, stares at their now linked hands, feeling complete from being barren for years. She stares at Sophia's eyes, asking questions, searching for something Sophia can't identify other than her thoughts. Sophia breaks the silence. "I… am here. I will listen" she mumbles, hazel staring at brown. Silence reigns in again, both of the girl's breathing audible. A minute passes, and both of them relax in each other's presence. Sophia, now her nervousness out of her system, revels in the touch that she had missed for five years since they last interacted heart to heart. She smiles, almost serene, until Cassie mutters the words.

“What happened between the last five years, Sophia?”



Shouts permeated through the wooden walls as she tried to listen in to the imp’s temptation. Words filled with hatred, exasperation and fear was all she heard. The adults in her life didn’t believe her whenever she says that she understands that her Mother and Father hated each other, and couldn’t seem to stand one another living in the same roof. But, she relents. They are adults. She will have her time when she becomes one. She tries to listen to them again, but squeaks in shock when she hears a loud slam throughout the household. Silence fills through the void, until only her Father’s silent hiccuping is audible to her five year old ear. She slowly opens the kitchen door, slightly ajar, and sees her Father’s hunched back, leaning on the kitchen table. She hears their family car rumbling and speeding off. She let out a relieved sigh. She approaches her Father and tugs on his shirt, now stained on something red, something she doesn’t understand. Her Father, where she inherits her hazel eyes, stares at her, shocked but quickly molds into worry and pretends as he asks her if anything is bothering her. She sees through him. She sees the cuts in his forehead, sees the bruises on his arms, sees him grimacing everytime he tries to hug her, sees him cry on the corner in the middle of the night when he thinks everyone is sleeping. He sees her Father in pain, but questions why he would bother lying to her. She doesn’t reply, wordlessly hugs him in comfort.

She hated her mom from the moment she understood that she also hated her existence.

“I hate those eyes”, she would always say to her. “Why do you act like a freak?” she would comment while she tries to play house and imagine herself as a model in one of her plays. “You are too ugly, you should be pretty like me”, she would hear her over and over again until she tires of it.

“You were a mistake I wish I had never done”.

Those were the words that hurt her the most. She learned early. She was grateful. At the very least, words won’t hurt her anymore. She was trained to endure it after all. The only happiest moments of her life was her playing Roblox with her close friends, the Melody keychain she had won over from her friend, and Cassie. Cassie always made her heart feel warm. She always felt giddy sneaking into her mansion despite Cassie’s parent’s insistence that she enter the normal way. “It’s more fun this way”, she always reasons. Cassie’s home was barren and felt lonely, but with Cassie by her side she’ll make it fun. It was always fun and fulfilling with her, despite her catty demeanor and attitude. She felt like Cassie was her sister, like a part of her soul that she always tried to find in people.She only found it inside Cassie, and she wouldn’t have it any other way.

Sometimes, Cassie worries her. She was very touchy, very affectionate. She doesn’t mind it, if anything, she finds it cute. But, in her child mind, Cassie's requests concern her. It was always related to her not leaving her behind or having her stay at her mansion past what her parents’ curfew. In spite of it however, she always backpedals, because as much as she is worried about

Cassie, she was also her knight in shining armor, locking her Mother's thoughts of her away from her mind by Cassie's warm hugs and words.

She should have known better that her Mother always had the last laugh.

She didn't want to move back to her Father's hometown. She understood, in her now eleven year old mind, that they needed to. This hometown only brought pain to her Father, and their finances were bled dry by their divorce. She tried to make her heart understand that they needed to do this, but a part of her doesn't want to leave at all. She wants to stay at Cassie's side. She still wants to be friends with Cassie. She doesn't care about what her Mother thinks about her thoughts. All she wanted was to be beside, fighting against the world alongside her.

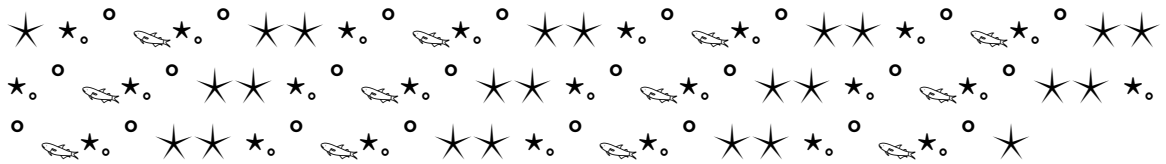
"Love is finite, you'll realize that someday Sophie."

The last words she uttered to her always felt disgusting. It's not, she tries to convince herself. Not to Cassie, not to my Dad, who you have hurt with your ugly words and body. Anger filled inside her veins. She vowed to herself that she wouldn't become like her mother, not in a million years if she could help it. Cassie, knowing about her situation and her moving out, always cried throughout the last week of them together whenever she tried to assure her that their friendship wouldn't fizz out, that they would always keep in contact with each other via Messenger, and it wasn't that hopeless. Both of them would then end up cuddling, along with imagining their future selves and the life that they would have when they would meet again.

“Please, don’t leave me…”

Still, the day of her departure came, and even with her powers as a child, she couldn’t prevent it. Cassie, upon her insistence, went out for the first time despite her parent’s wishes, to see Sophia off. Teary eyed, she gave her a letter, filled with hope and wishes for their future. Both hazel and brown stare at each other. Cassie pulls Sophia in one last hug, trying not to cry in front of her. Sophia grins out of habit, and takes her Melody keychain from her school bag. She takes Cassie’s right palm and places it on top of it. “This is my promise. I’ll come back Catty” she smiles with teeth visible, teary eyed. Cassie stares at the gifted keychain and grips it. She flashes Sophia a toothy smile. Sophia grins as she gets sauntered off into the moving truck. She maneuvers half of her body out of the truck window, waving her goodbyes to Cassie. Seeing Sophia’s actions, she tries to outrun the truck in her eleven year old body and shouts whilst forcing herself not to cry.

“Come back to me Princess!”



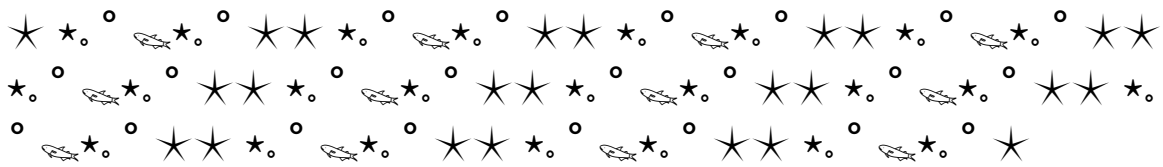
Cassie felt Sophia stiffen as she reiterates her question. She tries to read Sophia’s expressions, which range from guilt to anger and

then hurt. She felt confused. She doesn’t understand what happened throughout those years, what event prompted Sophia to ignore her when she came back to her hometown as a first year junior high school student. She tried to understand that maybe Sophia felt cornered as of the moment and may panic at the idea of confrontation. She places herself in front of Sophia, knees touching each other and two inches away from each other. She gazes at her hazel eyes, now darting from her eyes and to her sides, wanting to get away. She sees fear. She sees panic. She doesn’t want Sophia to feel uncomfortable at all. She had comforted her. It was a given. She tried to move away, but halted.

Isn’t it like time for both of you to resolve that rift you had since the first year?

She doubles down and takes Sophia's arms instead, eyes determined and focused. She mouths the thought that had always plagued her mind since it all started. “Please… talk to me Soph. I know you’re still in there”, she breaks, boring her gaze onto Sophia.

Sophia, with her fight leaving her body, speaks.



The first months apart were both the easiest and the hardest, with them still communicating via Messenger and video chatting. Sophia found all of those moments precious, especially with her still trying to cope with her new life at her Father's hometown. She had found new friends at her local school, but she never did feel close to them. Cassie to her, was enough. Cassie was the only person she let in within her broken walls, and she felt content with that. Those months of constant chatting with Cassie however, turned into weekly intervals, until such time that within the two years that Sophia had settled in her Father's hometown, they barely chatted anymore. It hurt her, but concern was the stronger feeling that plagued her mind.

Cassie had confided to her that in the same year that she left, she felt moved by her and attempted to make new friends at her school. Pride filled her heart, knowing that the once timid crybaby catty friend that she had once loved is growing. She was curious about her life, what type of people her friends were like, and if she ever talked about her in front of her new found friends. She convinced herself she felt happy for her, but a gnawing feeling, dark and sinister, crept into the crevices of her mind. She knew that a part of her felt abandoned, forgotten, and replaced from the new stage of Cassie's life. She knew that it wasn't true, that Cassie wasn't that cruel of a friend. Cassie loved her like no one else, and they were each other's soul's half. But she was resolute. Her mother's words weren't true. It was a fallacy, a delusion she made herself believe.

"We should visit your best friend's school then! We can accompany you while going there Soph. It will be the girl's first road trip!" her new friend at her hometown exclaimed as she told her the concerns she felt for Cassie. She felt validated for the first time, that her feelings were normal to feel, that she wasn't insane

for worrying. Excitement bubbled inside her for the first time ever since she moved into their hometown, and was giddy planning for the itinerary for their supposed trip. She tried to imagine what Cassie's reaction would look like about her surprise visit. She would probably cry in her arms, giddy, whilst telling her everything that happened in her life for the two years that she was gone. Cassie would probably introduce her to her new found friends, and she would happily befriend them. And she would be none the wiser.

Thursday came like a breeze. Both Sophia and her friend said their pleas to their respective parents, with both of them reasoning that they were now twelve years of age, mature enough to not get lost. They were permitted, but not without strong warnings. Exhilarated, they both boarded a bus going through her past home address. Two hours only felt like thirty minutes for Sophia, who kept on daydreaming and planning on how she would surprise Cassie about her arrival. They finally reached her past home address, where the wooden walls that she once felt through her fingertips whenever her parent's fought were now broken and decomposing. Moss covered the cement. The roofs were bent by the flow of time. Nostalgia crept into her bones yet she felt that it was inevitable. She grabs her friend by the arm, telling her to help her search for Cassie's school. Excitement kindled into her veins once again, as they animatedly searched for Cassie. She felt alive again. She never knew that she could feel this way again. Alive. Excited. Warm. Both of them were giddy as they finally traced Cassie's school. The girl, walking with vigor, tried to search for her friend throughout the building, hope kindling inside her. I want to see her again, she prays. Let me see her again, she prays once more.

She saw a familiar lock of brunette as her eyes glazed through the crowd of students. Her heart quickened, breath stopped as she tried to catch up to her. She zoomed through the dozens and dozens of elementary students going home, never stopping whenever someone blocked her way and view. She kept on

shouting, her desire to reach her grew even bigger. She didn't hear her friend calling out to her, if anything, she didn't mind. Cassie had always been her priority, She was her special person. She was also hers. The girl was finally one touch away from reaching her, but what she heard made her world stop turning.

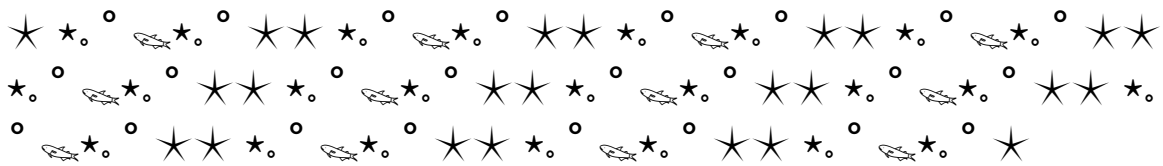
"Catty, that was so thoughtful of you!" the girl beside her exclaims as she hugs her, lifting her up, giggling. Cassie, from what seemingly looked like giddiness, laughs at her friend's actions and returns her affection.

Sophia, now a meter away from them, stood still, face indiscernible. She didn't know what to feel. Confusion, dread, and heartbreak was all what was painted on her face. Betrayal tasted like lead on her mouth. She couldn't believe it. She thought that the nickname she gave to Cassie was only hers for the taking. Cassie also shied away from other people's touch, but never from Sophia. Cassie craved it. She willingly let other people enter her personal space like it was theirs. Forgotten, yes… in the end, she was forgotten.

"Love is finite, you'll realize that someday Sophie."

No, she thought to herself. She wouldn't succumb to her mother's delusions. It was all false. She was wrong about her, about her existence, about the way love is. Determined, she followed Cassie and her friend for some semblance that she wasn't forgotten, that she was still her best friend, her kindred. What she saw however, only proved her wrong. Present at the bag of Cassie's friend, lay the Melody keychain, the exact one she gave her before moving away.

She should have known better that her Mother always had the last laugh.



"You… and that was it? We were kids Soph. What makes you think that just because I got busy and I learned to be receptive to affection meant that we weren't friends anymore?!" Cassie exclaims out of frustration, staring at Sophia like she was insane. "And due to that you antagonized me in our first year like I was invisible and that I was like what… a diva to boot? Are you kidding me Soph?" she mutters as she runs her hands at her now loose ponytail. Sophia, offended at the way she reacted, explodes in retaliation. "It wasn't just that Cass! We hadn't chatted for almost two years. I knew you. You would do everything just to make your parents happy, just for them to notice that you exist. You act like you are some sort of a hero but in reality, you are just as broken as me. Wanting attention, wanting to be touched, wanting to be loved, it wouldn't surprise me if you sought other people for that other than me" she imploded, closing their distance whilst staring at her brown eyes as she spoke "I would at least admit that I am broken, that I am not perfect and everyone aren't bound to like in the first place. Everything that I do is just a means for me to protect myself from unnecessary thoughts and connections that would leave me in the end. What are you doing pretending to be something that you are not, Cassie?". No words were spoken. The breeze only filled the stillness that lasted for minutes. They were

merely an inch from each other, Cassie still holding Sophia’s arms, eyes fighting and never backing down.

A sound of whimper and a bated breath was all Cassie could muster, eyes fighting for her tears not to roll down as she tried to reply to her. “I wanted to feel loved,” she whispered. “I wanted to fill the hole that was left when you left. I felt alone all over again. The only way that I could fill that hole was to mimic you, be more approachable and maybe, I could find friends I could confide with. It took years and numerous backstabbing and betrayals, but I found my people that I could finally feel close with. It wasn’t the same with you though…” She scoffed, her grip on Sophia’s arms weakening as she stared at a wall, contemplating. “You were the only one I could open up with, and the only one I could feel relaxed with…” she speaks softly, like a prayer. She went on. “That's why, I was so hurt when you ignored me when I went up and met you in first grade. It felt like a painful burn that didn’t go away, no matter how I tried to squash it down. A fog that wouldn’t disappear no matter how I try to make an effort to make it go away”. As she went on, her hands slid down from her elbows, to her hands. She squeezes her hands, reminiscing about the easiness she always felt whenever they held hands. Sophia's face, now contorting from stupor from Cassie’s vulnerability and honesty, she turns her head away from her. Cassie, having a moment of clarity from words spoken, had an epiphany. She never realized that what lay under Sophia’s unbothered and cheery personality was her insecurities and her warped perception of love coming from her abusive mother. She knew that in her younger years, whenever Sophia would have a solemn and glass look; her attention was far away from what they were doing. She would then coax her to cuddle together and probe on the reasons as to why she felt down, which always traced back to her mother. Little Sophie would then admit that she only ever felt safe inside her mansion, with her by her side.

And she was stupid to have never correlated it to their present dilemma.

"I know you Soph. I know about your past, and your tendencies, and I understand now. I know… that you think that people would abandon you in a split second if they find someone much more interesting. We're not kids anymore. Next year, we will go our separate ways for our dreams in life," she stares at her, eyes focused at hazel, "Before all of that happens, I want us to talk… I won't abandon you, Princess". She squeezes her hand for comfort, praying her message got through.

A moment of tranquil passes, lasting for minutes. Cassie hopes turns sour, head tilting down, her hands weakening her grip. She expected screams of apprehension and hate, but was shocked to realize that she felt wetness dripping from her elbows. She lifted her head and saw Sophia crying hushed tears, seemingly not wanting to bawl out in public. She mouths something she couldn't understand, but what felt like a thousand apologies that her voice couldn't bear to speak. Instead of forcing her to speak, Cassie notions her to lean onto her chest, under her chin, feeling her polo uniform wet with more tears. A broken, hushed voice could be heard between. "I don't want you to hate me…" Sophia cries. "I miss you Catty…" she whispers as a mantra as she continues to cry on her chest. Grinning, Cassie hugs the back of her neck, placing her nose on the Stygian hair she once liked. I missed you too, Princess, she thought, but never spoke.

Welcome back, Princess.

End Notes

Ended with a cliffhanger cause life moves that way. I want to possible make a sequel to this story, but somehow I only have a vague idea on how to approach it. I hope you had fun reading this little drabble of mine. :)

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